



THE BRAND-FUNDED DOCUMENTARY SYSTEM

MODULE 6

The Call, the Menu, the Number

Practical funding strategy for independent and documentary filmmakers

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The Call, the Menu, the Number

A brand replied. You have a call booked. This is the module where filmmakers either land a partnership or talk themselves out of one. The call has a structure, the offer has a menu, and the price has a logic. Learn all three and you'll walk into the conversation calm instead of anxious.

The two supporting assets here are **Template E, the Deliverables Menu**, and **Template F, the Valuation Worksheet**. Have both done before the call.

The call structure (25 minutes)

Twenty-five minutes, in this order. The order matters more than anything you'll say.

1. Their goals first (10 minutes of questions). You start by asking, not pitching. Spend the first ten minutes on questions like *"what does your content team wish it had access to?"* and *"what audience are you trying to reach that you can't reach now?"* You are not being polite. You are gathering the exact language you'll use to map your film to their needs. The filmmaker who pitches for ten minutes learns nothing. The one who asks for ten minutes learns what to sell.

2. Map your film's assets to what they said. Now, and only now, you connect. Take what they just told you and map your film's assets directly onto it. *"You said you want to reach rural communities authentically; that's exactly the audience this film has access to."* You're not delivering a canned pitch; you're answering the need they just named. Nobody knows your film better than you, so nobody can tie a brand's wants and needs to it better than you. You are the authority. No room for imposter syndrome.

3. The menu. Then you walk them through the Deliverables Menu and the tiers. You've earned the right to talk price because you've established value against their stated goals.

The Deliverables Menu (Template E)

Three tiers, concrete deliverables, priced off a single value **X**:

Deliverable

Title (\$X)

Presenting (\$0.5X

Supporting (\$0.2X)

"Presented by" opening credit

-

Logo in end credits + poster/key art

-

-

-

Premiere event naming + hosting rights

-

-

Licensed social cutdowns (n)

6

3

1

Employee/private screening + filmmaker Q&A

2

1

Behind-the-scenes content package

-

-

Category exclusivity (12 mo, named category only)

-

Impact-report co-branding

Deliverables are things like logo placement per DGA (Directors Guild of America) and festival norms, cutdown licenses, event rights, first-look, employee screening plus filmmaker Q&A. The tiers give the brand a real choice of scale.

Never grant, at any tier: script or cut approval, subject access control, perpetual exclusivity. These are the lines that turn a sponsorship into a loss of your film. They're not on the menu because they're never for sale.

Pricing logic (Template F, the Valuation Worksheet)

Here is the single most important pricing idea in this system: **price the marketing value, not your budget gap.**

A brand does not care that you're \$40,000 short. A brand cares what it's getting for its money measured against what that thing would otherwise cost them. So, you price the *value delivered*, not the *hole in your budget*. Work the worksheet:

1 Audience value. Realistic 24-month reach (festival seats + screenings + streaming estimate + partner-org audiences + social) × niche CPM (cost per thousand ad impressions). **Niche CPM runs \$30–80** for targeted niche audience, far above general CPM, because a niche audience is all buyers. = \$___

2 Content-library value. What would *n* licensed cutdowns plus BTS (behind the scenes) cost the brand to produce themselves? **Market rate is \$3k–15k per finished minute of branded content.** = \$___

3 Activation value. Premiere naming, screening events, talent appearances, priced against event-sponsorship comparables. = \$___

4 Title tier = $(1 + 2 + 3) \times 0.6–0.8$, a partner discount versus buying all of it separately. The brand pays less than à la carte because they're partnering.

Floor rule: never below 10% of production budget for a title sponsor. Below that, the deal isn't worth the strings.

Sanity band for indie docs: \$10k, \$150k per brand. If your worksheet spits out \$4,000, recheck your reach or your CPM. If it spits out \$600,000 for a small doc, you've inflated something. The band keeps you honest in both directions.

Stacking: you're not always looking for one savior. **Stack 2–5 brands** and **never sell exclusivity cheap**, exclusivity is the most expensive thing on the menu because it stops you stacking. If you have 2 or 3 brands come back, you can address how important exclusivity is for them directly. Share your price points for stacked (multiple) sponsors vis a vis exclusively one brand.

Negotiation basics

Three moves, that's the core:

- **Silence after the number.** State the number, then stop talking. The pause is uncomfortable and it is doing work. Whoever speaks first often concedes. Let it be them. Practice this with friends. Practice sitting in silence after a point or question is made or raised.
- **Concede deliverables, not dollars.** If they push on price, don't drop the price, remove a deliverable. This protects your valuation and teaches the brand that the price maps to real value, not to your nerves.
- **The "phased" option rescues stalled deals.** A development gift now, finishing funds on rough cut. When a brand can't commit the full number, phasing lets them start small and grow in. It has un-stuck more stalled deals than any other move.

Filmmaker to Filmmaker: Multiple times I've had brands come back on a project fixated on cost over value. I've always been successful in landing a deal when I outline the value of the offer and ignore the cost structure in these negotiations. Taking away a deliverable allows the sponsor or brand to consider their own needs and what that means and if they decide they can live with it, then you'll renegotiate from there. Often, they want all of what you are offering and realize that the only way to receive that is to pay for the value of what you're offering. In any negotiation, your strongest position is, "Always be prepared to walk away from the deal." When this is real for you, you'll be able to hold strong to the value of what you are offering. That doesn't mean to say you can't reconsider and decide for yourself if what they are offering still works for you, it's not a time to be obstinate. Just confident in what your film can represent to a brand.

The example thread continues

Dana (fictional; illustrative) takes the call with the regional health plan's marketing director.

She spends the **first ten minutes asking**. She learns the plan is under pressure to prove rural commitment to its members and wishes it had authentic content it didn't have to stage. Gold, she now knows exactly what to map.

She **maps**: "You want to prove rural commitment authentically, this film *is* that, and its audience is your members." Then she opens the **menu** and walks the tiers.

She'd done **Worksheet F** beforehand: her honestly sized niche reach at a niche CPM, plus the content-library value of six cutdowns and BTS, plus a named premiere's activation value. Title tier landed inside the indie-doc sanity band and above her 10%-of-budget floor. She proposes **Presenting** to this plan and holds one tier of room to grow.

The director pushes on price. Dana **doesn't drop the number**, she offers to trim a deliverable instead. Still a hesitation on committing the full amount this quarter. Dana offers the **phased option**: a development portion now, the balance on rough cut. That gets a yes-in-principle to keep talking. She plans to **stack**, this is one of two to three brands, not the whole budget, and she doesn't sell exclusivity cheap.

Common mistakes

- **Pitching in the first ten minutes.** Ask first. The questions tell you what to sell. Their answers inform you of where to focus.
- **Pricing your budget gap.** The brand doesn't care about your shortfall. Price the marketing value.
- **Dropping dollars under pressure.** Concede deliverables, not price. Protect the valuation.
- **Filling the silence after the number.** State it and stop. The pause works for you.
- **Selling exclusivity cheap.** It's the most expensive item because it blocks stacking. Charge for it or don't grant it.

- **Chasing one giant sponsor.** Stack 2–5. One savior brand is fragile; a stack is resilient.
- **Granting a forbidden term to close.** Script approval, subject access control, final cut, approval over any creative decisions, perpetual exclusivity... never, not for any number.

Action checklist

- ☐ Completed the Valuation Worksheet (F): audience value, content-library value, activation value, title-tier math.
- ☐ Confirmed your number sits above the 10%-of-budget floor and inside the \$10k, \$150k sanity band.
- ☐ Prepared the Deliverables Menu (E) with your X set; decided which tier you're proposing.
- ☐ Planned the call in order: 10 minutes of their goals, then map, then menu.
- ☐ Rehearsed the three negotiation moves: silence after the number, concede deliverables not dollars, offer phasing if stalled.
- ☐ Confirmed your stacking plan (2–5 brands) and your no-cheap-exclusivity line.
- ☐ Listed the never-grant terms so you won't concede one under pressure.

When you've got a yes-in-principle, don't celebrate yet, protect it on paper. Go to Module 7.